

NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 08

Death Is Repetition

Author

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Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus $\approx$ 90 min read aloud
Scenes	17
Version	2026-09-23 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne

Episode 08 — Death Is Repetition

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Logline

Two horns before the name. Pursuit in the Haze. Athena refuses murder and repeats it. Apollo names the tariff: evil is cheap. Hell is snow. Lance the Champion is not Lance-Rocket. Red hears a voice he has already seen.

Place in the arc

Due: candidacy; Houndoom announced; Looong live cry; 37.

Paid: Guardian seen; Night Shade as dissection; white hell; ethics of evil (Lance / Eusine).

Open: radio of the man in white; Green; Houndoom still in play.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Gold/Richter · Chris/Maria	Scyther / Seadra; Venomoth; crop
Apollo	Houndoom; corrupt order; hell = snow
Athena	Death as repetition; not the murder
Lance (Team Rocket)	Inhuman decency; Golbat
Lance (Champion)	Stopover — フタル
Eusine / Red / Green	37; Mt. Silver; tip

Places (EN anchors)

Radio Tower (summit, stealth passage) · Mt. Silver.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Levels (modified)

Camp	Note
Lance—Team Rocket	Golbat 36 · Weezing 34
Athena	All 37

Apollo	Murkrow / Koffing 39 · Houndoom 41
Gold/Richter	near 37
Chris/Maria	30–32
Eusine	Haunter 33 · Electrode 35

Moves / history

Pursuit: power 40 → 80 (recall, those who flee; doubled against flight). In Houndoom, Pursuit is not a biological move but an egg move in HGSS — a historical modification after the fact. The narrative does not justify it. Stat drops are not cancelled by recall. They typically last through each battle. In line with physical integrity.

Two Lances

Executive ランス (decency, Golbat) ≠ Champion ワタル (stopover). Never place both in the same scene heading.

The white, snowy hell

A quote from the protagonist Margaret Hale, from the 2004 BBC series ‘North and South’
I believe I have seen hell and it is white, it’s snow white

Screen durations (excluding titles)

Antediluvian return ≈ 50–55 s. Drawing on... 1 min 20–40. Discipline of evil 2 min 15–45. Corrupt order 4–6 min. White hell ≈ 1 min 50. Two approaches ≈ 2 min.

Frozen from P1

niveleur. Looong live Master Giovanni! hunting crop. Guardian of Hell. stealth passage. Seadra: she / her. Projection of attempted murder — not a film screening. Compromising immolation — not self-immolation.

BGM index — pieces (OST)

Scene	Piece	Span
Horns / decency / Athena	She Who Mauls	01:52– · 02:07 · 02:42 · 02:53 · 00:25–01:25 · 01:41–01:52
Immolation	Family in Heart	entry
Voice / Mt. Silver	Making Monsters	00:00–00:44
Voice	Red Eyes and Blue	02:57–03:05
Voice	Black Eyes	01:35–end

Corrupt order	Reborn	entry
Corrupt order	Thunder and Blood	01:16–
White hell / approaches	Light in This Darkness	00:00–01:52 · 01:52–
Venomoth	My Sister	02:09–

BGM index — traces

Address only.

Scene	BGM
Athena's projection	EP03 S02 04:00–04:54
Looong live...	EP07 S01 05:36–08:06
Two approaches	EP05 S02 18:12–18:59
Drawing on...	EP01 S02 10:00–10:21

Order of scenes

1. Horns in the Dark
2. Inhuman Decency
3. A Compromising Immolation
4. The Projection of Attempted Murder
5. The Paradox of the Trade
6. Lance's Stopover (Champion)
7. Intrinsic Savagery
8. The Antediluvian Return
9. Death Is Repetition
10. Drawing on Earlier Errors
11. The Discipline of Evil
12. The Urgent Tip
13. Looong live Master Giovanni
14. The Voice Known by Experience
15. The Corrupt Order
16. White and Snowy Hell

17. Two Distinct Approaches

The scenes are inserted here. The close follows the body.

Scene – Horns in the Dark

Top of the Radio Tower

BGM ‘She Who Mauls’ 01:52–end

Snow was falling silently outside. Inside, the air seemed to have thickened. Gold/Richter felt as though every breath took a little more effort. Scyther stood before him, but he already had the impression that the Pokémon was further away than it actually was.

He raised his hand. The movement was slow, almost hesitant. He sought that familiar focus, the one that allowed his Pokémon to draw on his strength. Scyther responded. Its blades opened slightly. Sword Dance. Gold/Richter *took care that Koffing was solid enough in physical Defence against Scyther.*

Apollo didn’t move.

BGM ‘She Who Mauls’ 02:07–

The Koffing floating between them changed texture. No command. Just a shift in the density of the air. The black mist spread faster, lower, as if seeking to cling to their bodies. It was no longer content merely to obstruct their vision: it seemed to absorb sound, weigh down their limbs, and make every movement more taxing. The Haze neutralised the build-up of physical power within Scyther.

Gold/Richter felt his stomach clench.

The air had become heavy, almost thick. Gold/Richter found it hard to tell whether it was the fog or his own body resisting every movement. Scyther stood before him, but he already had the impression that the distance between them had widened slightly.

He did not speak.

He reached for his belt and closed his fingers around the Poké Ball. The movement was crisp, yet there was a sense of restrained urgency. He no longer had time to hesitate.

He raised the Ball.

Just as the light began to envelop Scyther, something stirred in the mist.

It wasn’t a sudden leap. There was only a **light**, almost imperceptible **footfall**, as if something had moved with calculated precision. A sharp, muffled rustle followed, very close by. Then came the impact.

It was not a broad, haphazard collision. It was colder, sharper. As if the attack had been placed exactly in the right spot, at the right moment. Gold/Richter felt the recoil shoot up his forearm with a sharp, jarring force. The Poké Ball snapped back into his palm with an unnatural, almost hostile weight.

He clenched it instinctively, his breath caught in his throat.

BGM ‘She Who Mauls’ 02:42–

Two horns.

That was the first thing. Not a body. Not a name. Two black curves, all too distinct in the Haze, which imprinted themselves upon him at the very moment the theme shattered.

Gold/Richter recoiled a split second. Terror struck first. Then, immediately afterwards, something more unsettling: he didn't know what had just struck him. The shape was too precise for a beast hurled at random, too fleeting for him to grasp. A volatility. An outline that was already slipping away.

The mist did not lift.

It lowered itself in stages, as if consenting, layer by layer, to reveal what it had been concealing. First, a mass lower than Koffing. Then the base of the shoulders. Then the horns again — more stable this time — and dark red eyes, calm, not yet seeking battle. Only space.

Gold/Richter stood still.

A blankness took hold of him. Brief. Intermittent. His arm still burned where the Ball had rebounded, hostile, too heavy, but his mind lagged behind. He saw, yet he could not piece it together. The walls grew blurry again, then less so.

Apollo had not moved. Beside him the figure completed its landing. Houndoom. The name arrived late, like a translation.

It was not baring its fangs. It was simply breathing, slowly, deeply, as if it were already taking possession of the space. Its dark red eyes were fixed, almost calm. There was no chaotic ferocity in its demeanour. Only a kind of patience. Apollo had taken advantage of the black mist to replace Koffing with Houndoom.

Gold/Richter clenched the Poké Ball. It had not become any lighter. He felt as though something in his hand was refusing to let go completely.

He was struggling to gather his thoughts. The pain in his arm was still sharp, but that wasn't the only thing troubling him. Something was off about the way the attack had come about. It had not been a brutal assault, as he would have expected from a rabid Pokémon. It had been too... precise. Too well-aimed. As if the thing in the mist had known, with pinpoint accuracy, exactly when Scyther would be most vulnerable.

He glanced down briefly at the Poké Ball. His thumb slid mechanically over its smooth surface. He still couldn't quite put his finger on what was troubling him. But the feeling remained: this wasn't a beast's attack. It was something colder, more calculated.

Two thoughts nagged at him simultaneously, without any particular order.

The first: it had not been a head-on assault. It had taken him too long to *resize the blow* — to grasp it only by half, that it had been *Pursuit*, unleashed in the Haze, at the very moment when Scyther was no longer quite there, no longer quite his own. Houndoom had already played its part. Before it was spotted.

The second: he was too taken aback to go any further. To gauge the situation. To work out what this Pokémon had become under Apollo's aegis. The investigation came to an abrupt halt. He no longer had the composure for it.

BGM 'She Who Mauls' 02:53–end

Apollo was still looking at him with that same neutral expression. Almost polite. As if he'd simply opened a door and was now waiting to see what Gold/Richter would do.

The Houndoom was not growling.

It simply was.

End of scene

Scene — Inhuman Decency Lance

Radio Tower (sneak passage)

BGM 'She Who Mauls' from 00:25–01:25

The passage was narrow. The light from the emergency lamps never quite reached the corners. The air smelled of cold metal and ancient dust.

Haunter rose slightly. Its eyes narrowed. A pale, insistent wave of hypnosis spread towards the spot where Golbat had just been visible. It wasn't a genuine attempt to put it to sleep. Eusine and Haunter were looking for something else: reflexes, evasive manoeuvres, the way this creature handled the threat.

Golbat did not fall asleep. It flapped its wings once, then vanished into the thickest shadow—the one the moon's light could not reach through the bars. The retreat seemed forced. It was deliberate.

BGM 'She Who Mauls' from 00:41–

For several seconds there was almost nothing at all. Then rustling sounds began. Irregular. Sometimes very close, sometimes echoed off the metal walls. The flapping of wings drawing nearer without ever becoming distinct. Intermittently, a shrill, short, hideous screech pierced the darkness — not loud enough to be a real attack, just enough to maintain the tension and force the ear to listen out. Golbat wasn't charging. It was holding the space like a sentry. Like a nocturnal animal watching its prey before making up its mind.

Then, without warning, the flapping suddenly faded, without ceasing entirely.

BGM 'She Who Mauls' from 00:55–

Then, from the thickest darkness, a wisp of spectral light burst forth. Confuse Ray cut through the shadows like a cold blade and swept towards Haunter. The contrast was stark: the pallid glow sliced through the darkness like a blade. Haunter shifted aside in one fluid motion, just in time.

Immediately, the frequency of the wingbeats increased. Faster, more pronounced. Not a charge just yet. A sense of pressure. A way of building apprehension in the chest, of reminding them that the creature knew exactly where the two adversaries were.

Then the blades of air went out.

BGM 'She Who Mauls' from 01:15–

Air Cutter sliced through the air in several criss-crossing bursts. Haunter dodged. One of the trajectories, however, passed very close to Eusine. The gust of air brushed against his shoulder. Another half-step and it would have hit him.

Lance spoke almost immediately, in a calm, detached voice:

‘Oh, apologies for the miscalculation...’

There was neither sarcasm nor any overt threat in his tone. Only a professional, almost bureaucratic politeness, as if he were apologising for a routine miscalculation. His expression remained neutral. He wasn’t trying to conceal a murderous intent. Perhaps there wasn’t one.

Eusine looked at him. He didn’t feel that Lance had ordered them to target the trainer. Yet something in that impeccable apology, in that complete lack of anger, gripped his chest more firmly than a direct attack. It wasn’t horror. It was a more vague anxiety, harder to put into words: the discovery of an inhumanity that didn’t even need to hide itself.

Golbat, somewhere in the shadows, was still flapping its wings. More slowly now. It was waiting.

End of scene

Scene – A Compromising Immolation

Apollo vs Gold/Richter. Top of the Radio Tower

BGM ‘Family in Heart’

The battle had just begun between Houndoom and Seadra. The air was cold and tense. Gold/Richter watched Houndoom intently. He knew that this Pokémon currently posed the greatest threat to his team.

Seadra kept its distance; it did not charge straight away. Gold/Richter, for his part, did not give any orders straight away. He was waiting to see how Apollo would react.

At that moment he commanded Seadra to unleash **Icy Wind**.

The icy wind struck Houndoom head-on. Houndoom growled, its movements becoming noticeably heavier and less fluid. Gold/Richter hoped this would slow it down and make it more vulnerable.

Houndoom reacted instinctively. Without waiting for an order, it spat out a thick, black **Smog**, creating a toxic screen between itself and Seadra.

Apollo seized the moment. With a fluid motion and without the slightest hesitation, he recalled Houndoom into its Poké Ball. The movement was sharp, precise, almost martial. Without wasting a second, he flicked the next Poké Ball between his fingers and threw it in a single, sweeping, controlled motion.

The sphere cracked open in a burst of black and red.

At the very moment the Poké Ball began to open, the black mist of the residual Haze had already begun to dissipate, without Apollo having uttered a single command or made the slightest gesture. The veil withdrew of its own accord, as if the illusion were already losing its substance even before its bearer had fully materialised.

Murkrow’s silhouette took shape in the air, still thick with dark wisps.

No sooner had it materialised than the raven let out a piercing, almost mechanical cry:

‘Loooong live Master Giovanni...!’

The voice carried the altered, slightly distorted echo of the one Gold/Richter had already heard from Athena’s Murkrow. An automatic response. A litany that had become a reflex.

Gold/Richter stiffened.

It was no longer the word. It was the pattern. *Haze*, then *Pursuit*. The terror returned to him from the top of the Tower, intact, as if it had happened before, as though his body had remembered it better than his mind. He took half a step back, the hunting crop already raised — and, in the same breath, almost in spite of himself, his left hand slid towards the leveller.

The movement was fleeting. A stolen glance: regaining his grip, gauging the situation, no longer merely on the receiving end of a blow.

Apollo noticed.

Just a flicker. A glance too brief to be an accusation, too precise to be a coincidence. He’d seen the hand.

Murkrow did too.

Its positioning remained a little too predictable, its cry a little too automatic — as if the litany had frozen part of its instinct. But it knew how to make use of the interval. Gold/Richter’s lingering fear, and that split second granted to the tool, were enough for him. He turned towards Seadra, pivoting slightly. A brief, almost discreet cry. An unstable, dense and foul-smelling shadow burst forth from his body.

Night Shade.

Seadra absorbed the impact without being knocked back. The damage was not significant — Murkrow was not powerful enough to seriously threaten its sturdiness. But it was not the force of the attack that mattered.

It was the **manner in which it was delivered**.

The shadow did not strike like a brutal attack. It crept in, cold, precise, almost surgical. Seadra shuddered violently. A wave of dread swept through its body, more intense than the pain itself. It was as though Murkrow had, for a split second, **laid bare** and **needled** its vulnerability — as though, despite its high Defence, it had been struck where he should not have been, in a calculated and contemptuous manner.

Gold/Richter sensed the echo of this humiliation in his Pokémon. This was no ordinary fear. It was a deeper, almost existential distress: that of being reduced, if only for a moment, to prey being dissected with indifference. He clenched his teeth. This sensation was worse than simply being neutralised by a powerful move. It was torture.

It had to end. Quickly.

He quickly ordered Seadra to use **Agility** once more, in the hope that it could reposition itself and prepare its special attacks from a distance. However, the lingering **Haze** immediately nullified the effect. Seadra tried to move away nonetheless, but its body no longer responded with the same alacrity.

Murkrow did not have time to repeat its attack. Seadra, though slowed, struck back at close range with a critical-hit **Icy Wind**, using the **Sniper** ability. The icy wind violently scattered Murkrow's black feathers into the air, accompanied by a hoarse, piercing whimper.

Apollo recalled Murkrow.

As he closed the Poké Ball, his expression remained composed. There was only a very slight tension in his jaw. He did not immediately look away from the sphere. He knew the weight of that decision.

It was not a sadistic act of self-sacrifice. He took no pleasure in it. Yet he had not ruled out the option, should the need arise—if it had been necessary to ensure the system's continued operation. Now he was removing a component that was already damaged, before the cost became pointless. He knew the consequences, and the unseen price: what is cut short too soon, what is kept on too long, what the litany leaves in one's hand when one closes it.

Without hesitation, he took out the **Houndoom** Poké Ball and threw it with force. The trajectory was not perfectly straight: Apollo had deliberately aimed it so that the ball would land in the area still shrouded in residual **Haze**, right next to Seadra.

Gold/Richter followed the ball's movement with his eyes. Something about the throw struck him as unusual, but he didn't have time to think about it.

Houndoom burst out of the black mist like an ancient shadow.

Its leap was not that of a rabid beast. It unfurled in the air with a sinister, almost silent economy of movement, as if this motion belonged to a species that had never needed to roar to kill. Before Seadra could complete its retreat, it struck her head-on.

The bite was deep, intrusive, almost intimate. The fangs did not merely bite: they sank in and **clamped down**, locking Seadra in a vice-like grip of flesh and bone. Houndoom did not growl. It did not let go. It held the grip, its body pressed against that of its prey, like an ancient vampire refusing to let go of the neck it had chosen. The effect of Flinch was not merely a shock: it was a moment of forced submission, in which Seadra found herself immobilised in a closeness she had never learnt to handle.

Seadra tried to break free. She used Agility once more, desperately seeking to regain the distance where her special attacks would once again reign supreme.

But Houndoom would not allow it.

As soon as Seadra began to back away, the Houndoom tensed its entire body. This was not merely a reaction to prey making a break for it. It was a **ritualised** response: its whole body seemed to remember, with almost too much clarity, that any prey attempting to escape must be punished on the spot. The Pursuit that followed was of heightened, almost disproportionate violence, as if the Pokémon viscerally rejected the very idea that its prey could be snatched away from it. The bite tightened one last time before the impact hurled Seadra backwards.

The image cut off abruptly on that relentless leap, almost ceremonial in its brutality.

End of scene

Scene – The Projection of Attempted Murder — Athena

Radio Tower

BGM ‘She Who Mauls’ from 01:41–01:52

Snow was falling outside, fine and silent. Inside the tower, the air was drier, heavy with the smell of hot cables and ancient dust. The floor was one level below where Apollo was. The light there was sparse.

Chris/Maria took her position. Venomoth spread its wings with a precise flutter. On Athena’s shoulder, Murkrow remained perfectly still, its eyes half-closed, as if it were not taking part. Arbok, meanwhile, was already occupying the centre of the space, its body half-erect.

Chris/Maria raised her hand. The movement was precise, almost surgical: two fingers slightly apart, a twist of the wrist. Venomoth understood. A yellow powder, less dense than Sleep Powder, was released in a horizontal cloud and headed towards Arbok.

Arbok lunged immediately. It was not clear whether it was preparing to use Glare or Crunch. Its movement was too fluid, too direct. Then, gradually, its muscles began to respond with a delay. Paralysis was setting in.

Athena said nothing for several seconds. She was observing the whole scene: the precision of the young girl’s movement, her coordination with Venomoth, the way the powder had been measured out. Murkrow, almost imperceptibly, flapped its wings once. A very fine wisp of air dispersed what remained of the powder in the air.

Then Athena spoke, in a calm, almost admiring voice:

“How phenomenal...”

BGM “EP03 S02 04:00–04:54”

Chris/Maria did not reply. She kept her eyes fixed on Arbok.

“You’re not as powerful as the boy,” Athena continued. “But you’re more skilful when it comes to organising a fight. Even more so than the one with red hair.”

She paused briefly:

“So you’re both... the ‘Professor’s’ protégés?”

Chris/Maria’s gaze clouded for a fraction of a second. Just long enough. Athena said nothing more. She’d had her confirmation.

Chris/Maria sat up slightly. She asked:

“So... if your intuition is correct... are you going to kill me too?”

Athena tilted her head ever so slightly, as if the question surprised her.

“Oh no. I never wanted to take this boy’s life.”

“How...?”

"I eliminate those who interfere with our plans. Neutralise them. Hurt them. Punish them a little, if necessary. But kill them? That's unnecessary."

Chris/Maria felt irritation rising within her.

"So we can torture them... as long as we do not actually kill them? How obscene."

"Why all this hypocrisy? Pokémon aren't the real threat. They only obey their Trainers, most of the time. Cutting off the source of the orders... isn't that a more effective way to stabilise a situation?"

"...What heresy."

Athena regarded her for a moment, almost curiously.

"And you... where do you get this intention you're attributing to me? The one I didn't have. Unless... is it actually mine?"

Chris/Maria did not reply straight away; her demeanour suggested she had anticipated this twist. Athena continued:

"Or perhaps... it is yours. If I were in your shoes, you'd be the one to murder me. What a primitive notion..."

The smile that accompanied these words was almost simple. Almost innocent. It was impossible to tell whether it was a calculated provocation. Athena had just deflected the accusation with cold precision. Chris/Maria had never been on the receiving end of an insult of this nature.

"My responsibilities," Athena continued in a lower voice. "They were either to neutralise the intruders or to divide them. I've accomplished one of the two. So I have no reason to go after this boy."

"... All right. What about the ambush?"

Athena understood immediately.

"Yes. But from what I can see... Lance is off on a little date at the moment."

Chris/Maria did not permit the silence to linger. She gave another signal. Venomoth fired a Psybeam. The beam struck Arbok squarely. It was super effective, yet the disparity in level and Venomoth's type curbed its might. Arbok staggered but did not collapse. Athena noted the blow with a single glance.

Arbok, still slowed, attempted a Poison Sting. The sting went wide.

Athena continued, as if nothing had happened:

'I said that this boy would have considered himself lucky to keep me company... because I wouldn't actually have killed him.'

"Oh... but would Apollo do it?"

A very slight flicker of her eyelid betrayed that Athena hadn't anticipated the name being recognised. She gave no further sign of it.

'...No. Not him. His Pokémon. The Guardian of Hell.'

"How formidable, your director..."

“As for his fear... I’ve managed to control my temper better by working with him. Occasionally, when I was on the verge of losing my temper, he’d stop me. He would talk me round. He’s exposed to it too, but he almost always keeps himself under control. Clear-headed. Realistic. Very few manage that. Almost inhuman... but ingenious. He deserves my praise for that.”

Chris/Maria had no time to reply.

A poisonous projectile sliced through the air with sudden agility. It grazed Venomoth so closely that the young girl jumped. Her Pokémon’s Poison-type reduced the impact, but the faint rustling sound was more macabre than the injury itself.

When she looked back at Arbok, the creature was straightening up. The symptoms of paralysis had completely vanished. A snake’s skin, cracked and incomplete, lay beside it. Arbok was shedding its skin before her very eyes, its tongue flickering, its eyes sparkling in the dim light.

BGM ‘Thunder and Blood’ 00:25–27

Chris/Maria realised.

‘How...? This Arbok’s Ability is “Shed Skin” ...’

Athena did not reply. She merely examined it, with a formal coldness. Perched on her shoulder, Murkrow gave a neutral, detached smile, like a bystander who had seen the scene a thousand times.

The distance was already too short for Venomoth to escape easily.

Arbok lowered itself onto its belly. Then it propelled itself forward with greater alacrity than usual. Its eyes opened wide.

Glare.

The scene ended on that predatory, ritualised, almost vampiric gaze fixed on its prey.

End of scene

Scene – The Paradox of the Trade Apollo

Top of the Radio Tower

The snow continued to fall outside, now heavier. On the tower’s top floor, the wind caused the metal structures to vibrate faintly. The air was cold, dry and charged with a tension that did not stem solely from the fight.

BGM “EP02 S01 00:00–02:32” .

Fearow hovered in the air, its wings spread but motionless. Opposite it, Houndoom barely moved. Its breath formed small, dark wisps of mist. It did not growl. It observed. An ancient, ritualised vigilance that bore no resemblance to the restlessness of an ordinary Pokémon.

Gold/Richter held his ground. Yet he was exposed. Two of his Pokémon were already down. His fatigue and frustration remained contained, visible only in the stiffness of his shoulders.

Apollo stood slightly to one side. His presence was light, almost ghostly. It was as if he moved without really taking up any space. Yet every micro-movement Houndoom made seemed to pass through him.

He spoke first, in a calm, almost conversational tone:

‘How unusual, this tool of yours...’

Gold/Richter felt anxiety tightening its grip.

“Every time I sent out a new Pokémon, you checked that gadget,” said Apollo. “It was supposed to give you some... constructive information. But the results were frustrating, weren’t they?”

Apollo saw no need to press further; he had seen enough. Since the information had not tipped the balance, his vigilance eased. Practicality now took precedence over curiosity.

Gold/Richter understood. The leveller had been discovered. After the Pokédex, it was this device’s turn. His frustration deepened yet further.

Apollo continued, in the same detached tone:

‘I must admit your excellence as a Trainer. Your performance exceeds what I had anticipated. I’m sorry to have... advantages that are somewhat underhand. By common standards.’

The praise sounded strange. Deferential, almost pedantic, yet distant. As if he were apologising for winning whilst claiming victory.

Gold/Richter forced a composed expression.

“Praise accepted. But it seems the result wasn’t... quite what you’d hoped for?”

“I underestimated your ability. Despite the intelligence and my assessment. Not precise enough... but not too far off either. Still manageable, I hope.”

“So the unpredictability unsettles you?”

“No. It enables me to refine my empirical intuition.”

His tone had shifted slightly. His earlier modesty suddenly seemed more theatrical. Gold/Richter sensed the dissonance without being able to put a name to it.

Fearow continued to size up Houndoom. Suddenly, a half-black mist escaped from the dog’s mouth. Smog. Not a full cloud. A calculated, limited jet, just enough to force a retreat.

Fearow dodged aside with its usual agility. Houndoom lunged immediately. As the distance narrowed dangerously, Fearow used Mirror Move and sent a similar wisp of mist back.

Houndoom halted abruptly and took a measured step backwards, out of range. Though the Smog’s potency was low, it refused to risk even a hint of poisoning. An ancient, pragmatic, almost ritualistic reflex. Then it resumed its stance, its gaze objective and predatory, difficult to read even for an ordinary wild Pokémon.

The situation stabilised for a moment. Gold/Richter was finally able to speak:

‘It’s inconceivable... your technique.’

Apollo waited for him to continue without interrupting.

"You're not a Master Trainer in the... usual sense," said Gold/Richter. "Your superiority seems to rest mainly on the difference in level."

A silence fell.

"Houndoom normally excels in special attacks. Yours sets that strength aside. Bite... Fire Fang, power 60 and 65... even Smog... power 30. Basic moves. No advanced moves. No TMs. This approach is... inconsistent."

Gold/Richter pressed on with some effort, piecing the facts together one by one.

"It looks as though you're not really aiming for victory. As though you're only here to buy time."

Apollo remained silent, composed, without interruption.

"...No. You're no amateur," said Gold/Richter. "Your knowledge of battle is extensive."

A very brief flash crossed Gold/Richter's mind: the way Apollo had thrown Houndoom's Poké Ball directly into the lingering mist of Haze, with deliberate precision.

'You threw the Ball into the fog... on purpose. Murkrow hadn't used Haze just to hinder me. It was protecting your own. You sacrificed Murkrow because a slowed-down Houndoom would have jeopardised your victory. And Haze also negated the effect of Seadra's Icy Wind.'

Apollo replied matter-of-factly:

"We sometimes have to make compromises. It wasn't a pointless waste."

Gold/Richter continued, his voice more tense:

"Incidentally... your Houndoom is almost autonomous. You haven't given it any visible orders. It acts on its own. With a precision... that's empirical. Or predatory. Not quite like a guardian of hell. Nor like an ordinary wild Pokémon. An intelligence... abstruse. Ancient."

Apollo's face remained impassive.

"A trainer who is no amateur... with Pokémon so raw, so immanent... it's without parallel," Gold/Richter mused. "I don't understand this dynamic."

The enigma was undermining Gold/Richter's composure. His focus was wavering.

Apollo took advantage of this.

BGM 'Greatsword' 00:00–00:29

He spoke more quietly, with a hint of genuine interest:

"As a scrutineer. I expected nothing less from a Pokédex holder."

Gold/Richter felt a chill of foreboding run through his mind.

"Your previous question..." said Apollo. "What is my area of specialisation..."

Apollo made a very slight gesture, barely more pronounced than usual. No excessive theatrics. Just the quiet confidence of someone who knew the moment had come.

"My speciality... is intrinsic savagery."

The silence that followed was heavier than any attack.

Gold/Richter stood motionless. He felt as though he himself had lit the fuse. As though, through his own empirical naivety, he had forced the revelation he should have avoided.

Across from him, Apollo regarded him with icy serenity. A man in a graceful, almost elegant outfit, presiding over organic savagery as one presides over a protocol.

Gold/Richter's expression had sagged slightly. No panic. Just a kind of lucid despondency, and the onset of a quiet horror.

End of scene

Scene – Lance's Stopover

Elm's house. New Bark Town

The snow had deepened without warning. Inside Elm's house, the light was yellow and dim. You could hear the wind rattling the shutters.

Elm placed a cup of tea in front of Lance, then sat down opposite him, keeping a slight distance.

BGM 'EP03 S02 08:10 08:50'

Lance took the cup:

"Thank you."

The warmth spread through his fingers. He didn't drink straight away. His gaze lingered somewhere between the table and the window.

"So... is Gold/Richter fighting them over there right now?"

'Presumably,' replied Elm.

Lance nodded barely.

"They have chosen snowy days, as well as taking the trains out of service. No need to destroy them completely. Just enough to cut off reinforcements from Kanto. It is... calculated."

Elm looked at him for a moment.

'Are you worried we won't make it there? Or that their leader has become... harder to get hold of?'

Lance didn't reply straight away. He turned the cup slightly in his hands.

"It's not that. Even if we can beat them in a fight... it's not certain we can actually stop them."

He said no more. The implication hung in the air.

After a moment, in a lower voice:

"Green's out at sea at the moment. It must be weighing on him this time."

Elm didn't reply. He turned towards the window. Outside, there was nothing but snow – thick, endless snow that was already blurring the outlines of the garden.

A silence settled between them, heavy and insurmountable.

End of scene

Scene – The Intrinsic Savagery of Apollo

Top of the Radio Tower

BGM 'EP04 S01 00:00 → 01:20'

Gold/Richter stood motionless for a long moment.

'Intrinsic savagery...?'

It was not bewilderment; rather, it was the realisation of an answer he had already glimpsed but lacked the courage to confront head-on.

Fearow and Houndoom were barely moving. They were still sizing each other up, but their Trainers seemed, for a moment, to have left them behind. As if they knew that, in any case, the Pokémon would manage just fine.

Apollo remained perfectly composed. When he spoke again, his voice was calm, slightly narrative, almost oratorical, without ever rising in pitch:

'I developed this concept whilst tracking down Red. Even though he never faced me directly, nor did we ever meet in person. What was wearing him down wasn't so much Giovanni... it was the grunts. The ceaseless sorrows they represented. Contrary to what the masses imagine.'

He spoke of Team Rocket's dissolution as a blessing, not a disaster. Neither aversion towards Red nor gratitude.

Gold/Richter frowned slightly.

"You speak... as if you were indebted to him for your disbandment."

"Yes. It was an opportunity to grow. I made the most of it."

He paused very briefly.

"And you're the best person to judge, aren't you? Since you're already... a regular of ours."

The allusion jogged his memory. Brief, vivid, unpleasant images: a Golbat's Leech Life, a Raticate's Confuse Ray and Screech, Hyper Fang and Sucker Punch, a Koffing's Self-Destruct, an Arbok's Glare followed by Crunch — the one that had nearly caught him from behind.

"Are you talking about your Pokémon... during your... previous operation?" Gold/Richter speculated.

"Yes. Confuse Ray. Hyper Fang. Pursuit. Sucker Punch. Glare. Self-Destruct. None of these moves are particularly powerful. But they're tenacious. Vile. Insidious. And above all... used by ordinary, almost insignificant creatures, even at low levels. Remarkably precocious."

Gold/Richter shook his head ever so slightly.

"That's not... sensible. Organisations of this sort seek out the strongest. The legendary ones. It's... absurd."

He deliberately avoided saying 'to conquer the world'. The phrase seemed too naive, even coming from his own mouth.

Apollo watched him for a moment:

"Excellent points. However... you do not even seem to really believe it yourself."

Gold/Richter did not reply. His profile shifted slightly, as if he were retreating from a position that had become untenable.

Apollo continued, still in the same measured tone:

'You've made it this far virtually unscathed. That shows your companions have shared the burden. You're facing me at a disadvantage, whilst the majority of Trainers don't reach your level. And you're doing it out of a sense of responsibility. Just like Red. One could say you're worthy of being his successor... in that respect, at least.'

The praise rang hollow. Almost mocking. "You have the makings of it, but not yet the calibre," continued Apollo. "And you're a skilled Trainer, not through brute force, but because your Pokémon are disciplined, knowledgeable, relatively independent... despite some reliance on TMs. You trust them to follow their instincts."

Out of the corner of his eye, Apollo gestured towards Fearow. Gold/Richter followed his gaze despite himself.

"As for me... my approach aligns somewhat with yours."

Gold/Richter raised his head slightly:

"Are you implying... that you favour these... urban pests because they already possess these abilities innately?"

"Quite so. It brings to light the banal, ubiquitous evil that lies dormant within everyone."

"But that applies only to these Pokémon. Not to all beings. Nor to humans."

Apollo tilted his head slightly, as if accepting the distinction whilst at the same time transcending it:

"One of your questions interests me. Why would you want a Mewtwo? Capturing it and keeping it close is a constant threat to an ordinary trainer. It would be Mewtwo enslaving the trainer... not the other way round."

Gold/Richter realised where this was leading. He replied reluctantly, driven by an inner compulsion:

"Because they lack discipline. Resources. An education...?"

"Quite right. In the past, Team Rocket prioritised them as symbols of evil. I, on the other hand, choose them all the more because they're already functional from birth. Low-cost. Highly economical. Sophisticated features like TMs remain optional. Evil doesn't need to be spectacular to be terrifying. It simply needs... to be equipped at a reasonable price, and properly positioned, to function well."

An older, half-forgotten phrase came back to Gold/Richter's mind. He couldn't quite grasp it fully.

"So... that was it, your true objective in Ecruteak City," said Gold/Richter. "A trial. By mass slaughter."

Apollo read the recollection on his face.

“Yes. All you need to do is distribute these highly autonomous, extremely wild Pokémon to untrained people, ensure a minimum level of safety for the operators, then release them and let them get on with it. This is my new method. I’m lowering the threshold for accessing evil. More people can take part. This significantly reduces the budget and increases profitability. Far more so than chasing after exceptional Pokémon.”

BGM ‘EP02 S01 06:30 → 07:28’

Gold/Richter lowered his voice slightly.

“You’re recycling... mere scrap...?”

There was a note of contrition in the word. He was wary of disparaging Pokémon, even those he had found detestable.

Apollo replied with a cynical, almost empathetic melancholy:

“Rubbish, as you call it, can become devastating... provided it accumulates in sufficient quantities. And it can defeat even the strongest heroes.”

The insinuation hit home. Gold/Richter realised he was also talking about Red. Recognising this truth, under these circumstances, was particularly frustrating. He forced himself not to give in.

Houndoom then took a few steps back, positioning itself at a safer, opportunistic distance. It barked once. Softly, pragmatically. Without raising its head. In its normal stance.

It was not a display of superiority. Nor was it intimidation. It was a ritualised, spontaneous synchronisation that did not originate from Apollo.

The bark echoed across the floor and seemed to spread out into the snow outside, like a very ancient, almost antediluvian acoustic atrocity.

Then silence returned, heavier than before.

End of scene

Scene – The Antediluvian Return

A street in Goldenrod City

Houndoom’s bark reached this far, muffled by the snow but still recognisable. A deep, ancient note that seemed to echo through the whole city.

In a side street in Goldenrod, three trainers going about their business had stopped. They were all looking in the same direction: the Radio Tower, barely visible behind the white curtain.

Krise held her arms crossed over her chest. Her shoulders were slightly hunched. Her anxiety was most evident there, in the way she held herself, rather than on her face.

Mike noticed this. He did not turn to face her straight away. Several seconds passed.

Then, without looking directly at her, in a calm, almost formal voice:

‘Are you worried about Johto’s fate...?’

Krise did not look up at him. Her gloom prevented her from doing so:

BGM “EP04 S02 15:00–15:19”

“...Yes. But first we must look after those who protect us. I can only wish them the very best. Otherwise... I don’t think we’d deserve peace.”

Silence fell once more.

Mike waited a moment, then turned to Bryan, out of a sort of professional integrity, as if the question had to be put to the one who knew the sky best.

“Say, Bryan... are those the Gods of Death...?”

As he spoke, he cast a quick glance towards the streetlamp. Two Murkrow had alighted there. Motionless. Far too alert for mere passing birds.

Bryan shook his head slightly. His gaze remained matter-of-fact, professional:

“No. They don’t really herald death.”

He paused.

“Rather, they signal... the return of something. Something very dreadful. Something those who came before us have already experienced. And which, after centuries, still lingers somewhere within us.”

The two Murkrow did not stir. They gave the impression of listening, even though they were out of earshot.

Then one of them spread its wings and flew away silently, gliding through the snow like a shadow.

The three Trainers remained silent, their eyes still fixed on the tower.

End of BGM ‘EP04 S02 15:00–15:19’

End of scene

Scene – Death is the Repetition Athena

Radio Tower

BGM ‘Vive la révolution’ 02:01–02:23

Arbok’s Glare had dissipated without effect.

Venomoth remained in flight, its wings steady, showing no sign of paralysis. Arbok, for its part, seemed briefly taken aback. Its head swayed from side to side, as if it were still seeking confirmation of a result that failed to materialise.

Athena watched the scene with a calmness tinged with scepticism. No panic. Just a keener curiosity.

Chris/Maria felt the lingering tension wash over her shoulders. She hadn't been sure that Shield Dust would be enough. She'd remained vigilant right to the end. Now that the immediate danger had passed, a slight daze was overtaking her. She held it back.

She gave a faint smile, just enough to mask the sense of inferiority she felt.

'I'm sorry that Providence was on our side. My Venomoth's special ability is Shield Dust. It evaded Glare... by luck. But in the face of your... thoughtful surprise.'

The remark sounded more provocative than she'd intended. She hadn't been trying to make herself look better. She'd simply been trying not to appear entirely vulnerable. She knew that completely concealing her position would have put her in even greater danger.

Athena smiled. A barely perceptible smirk, almost one of delight, which didn't really weigh down the atmosphere.

"You're... more interesting than you seem. Really."

Chris/Maria showed a little more caution.

"Besides... you don't want to kill us, do you? To avoid turning us into martyrs. Sorry if that's too naive a question."

Athena tilted her head slightly, as if the question were so familiar to her it had become tiresome.

"No need for that humility. No. Turning heroes into martyrs has consequences... that are difficult to manage without preparation. But the impulse is always there. In the short term, especially."

Chris/Maria felt a strange sensation. It was not a calculated insult. It was almost an everyday remark—hollow, detached. A sense of apathy crept over her despite herself.

Athena continued, in the same sanitised tone:

'A disabled hero, not very effective, but alive... is more ideal for someone like us. He becomes predictable. Lacking in adaptability. And his limited influence on those around him... becomes a rarer commodity, I presume.'

Chris/Maria subtly lowered her eyelashes. Athena spoke again:

"In my view, it is actually the gentlest way to honour a valiant figure. His sacrifice as a martyr might begin with a spark... then fade. He would fall into oblivion, or be reduced to a symbol. A cruel truth. Apart from speculative martyrdom...: this reduction to a symbol has gained a value... of which he would not have been worthy in any case."

There was nothing impassioned about Athena's account. She simply seemed weary of conventional nonsense.

Chris/Maria continued, in a lower voice:

'...But you're not planning to defuse me.'

"No. You have demonstrated certain merits outside of combat. As a student of the Professor."

Arbok then changed his approach. He lowered his body slightly and let out a measured Screech. The sound was not aimed at the trainers. It remained within a calculated range, just loud enough to be heard, just directed enough to test the waters.

Venomoth reacted immediately. Thicker powders escaped from its wings, thickening the screen between it and the snake.

Then, without warning, Murkrow opened its beak.

‘Loooong live Master Giovanni...!’

BGM “EP06 S01 00:10–02:57”

The voice was Lambda’s. Exaggerated, almost hysterical, as if the bird had been holding back a smile for a long time and was now letting it all out.

Chris/Maria started inwardly.

“So... is he a god of death... or an actor?”

Athena absent-mindedly ran her hand over Murkrow’s waxed feathers, brushing them lightly.

“That’s what they call him in Kanto. A more popular alias. More understandable.”

Her tone suggested she was tired of explaining it.

“He does not actually bring about death. Nor does he foretell it. Or very rarely. In any case, not the death to come. Rather, that... of the past.”

Chris/Maria frowned slightly.

“In reference to what?”

“Most people fear the dark, death, bad omens – the things they don’t understand. They gave it that name. Instead of rejecting it, it recycles these selective fears. It uses them to probe what people truly dread.”

Athena paused. The playful tone had gradually faded.

“Future death isn’t the most terrible thing. It’s death in the past. We think we understand it... when in fact we know almost nothing about it. And we keep repeating the same mistakes. Without ever breaking the cycle.”

She spoke more slowly.

“Murkrow often repeats old tricks. Rarely anything entirely new. But he examines why we’re afraid, and what we don’t know. Then he adapts. He optimises rather than invents.”

A silence fell.

“If a proverb says that death is a beginning... or a liberation... it may just as well be... a repetition.”

His tone had grown sombre of its own accord.

“It often works that way. Death isn’t frightening in itself. It reminds us why we fail, and why we’re reluctant to admit our mistakes, our ignorance. We repeat ourselves. We stagnate. We remain trapped in the same labyrinth. A concept that resonates with that of Apollo. But I occasionally wonder why this Pokémon performs better with me than with him. Is it mine... or his?”

Chris/Maria tentatively offered one last, cautious clarification.

“So... if it undertakes its trial of its own accord, even when acting on behalf of another...”

Athena gave a faint smile. A conviction tinged with cautious delight, like someone who knows full well they’re playing with fire.

‘I get that feeling from time to time. All the better. We’re on the same wavelength.’

Chris/Maria could not make sense of this reaction. She remained on her guard, mentally, unable to decide whether she had just made progress or dug herself deeper into a hole.

All around them, snow continued to fall against the tower’s windows. Murkrow kept one eye half-closed, as if he were still assessing the situation.

End of scene

Scene – Learning from past mistakes

Top of the Radio Tower

BGM ‘EP05 S01 07:32–08:22’

Gold/Richter sat up slightly. He had just swept his gaze over the all-too-obvious frustration. He could not afford the luxury of remaining slumped over.

‘Right... Thanks for the information. It stems... from an unusual creativity.’

The sarcasm was defensive, measured; just enough not to appear entirely overwhelmed.

Apollo didn’t smile. He remained motionless, with that way of his that made him seem barely present in his own body.

“To explore creativity... inventing something new isn’t the only way. Often, it’s enough to draw on what already exists. True innovation lies in building on what comes before.”

Gold/Richter opened his mouth, then thought better of it.

Apollo continued, in the same even tone:

“Savagery is nothing new. It goes back a long way. We need only take up the elements left behind by those who came before us.”

Gold/Richter could not help but sense the irony. To hear an adversary speak of building on the legacy and wisdom of one’s ancestors created a dissonance that was hard to stomach at his age.

“Are you suggesting... that we should draw on their wisdom?”

“I’m afraid not. It’s rather the opposite.”

A look of surprise briefly flashed across Gold/Richter’s face.

“Don’t get me wrong,” said Apollo. “I’m not obsessed with history. Historians often complicate matters more than they clarify them. But their fixation forces me to look at recurring mistakes... rather than comfortable glorifications.”

He paused very briefly.

“Their mistakes allow us to repeat the same ones. They are also exploitable. Their aberrations, their ritualisations, their blind spots, their inconsistencies... all of that remains at our disposal. I draw on their wisdom... but in the opposite direction.”

Gold/Richter asked, in a lower voice:

“Do you think you’re smarter than them?”

“Not at all. History is broadly divided into two phases: survival through stagnation, and evolution. Their imperfection gives this world its depth. You never know which blind spot you’ll run into... or which one you’ll manage to avoid. Otherwise, life would be far too monotonous.”

Gold/Richter understood that this wasn’t disdain. Just an observation. What troubled him was the dissonance with everything he’d been taught to regard as certain.

Apollo added, almost as an aside, in a more erratic tone:

“In all honesty... I’m neither very superstitious nor particularly religious. But certain dogmas — the seven deadly sins, for example — strike me as excessively abstruse. And biased. It makes the world... less than ideal, I must admit.”

He didn’t elaborate. The sentence hung in the air, as if set aside for later.

All around them, the snow continued to fall against the tower’s structure. Houndoom hadn’t moved. Neither had Fearow.

The silence that followed was heavier than words.

End of BGM ‘EP01 S02 10:00–10:21’ in full

End of scene

Scene – The Discipline of Evil Lance

Radio Tower, Surreptitious Passage

BGM: ‘Powerful Predatory Deadly’ 01:30 or later

Both fields remained almost intact.

Few visible marks. Yet psychological weariness had set in, thick as inner snow. Every exchange of glances exacted a heavier toll than the previous blows.

Golbat occupied the shadows, wings half-spread, almost motionless. Haunter hovered lower, alert.

Eusine watched for a moment. He assumed—with an ambiguous conviction, sufficient but not absolute—that Lance and his Pokémon’s attention had just wavered slightly.

He held out his hand. Haunter's Poké Ball returned to him in a sharp, almost mechanical movement. Lance raised his eyebrows slightly. It was not the decision he had been expecting.

Eusine immediately threw Electrode's Poké Ball. The sphere opened. Electrode appeared, already spinning slowly.

Lance looked briefly taken aback. It wasn't fear of the type disadvantage. It was a deeper deliberation, as if he were recalculating something.

He made a tiny, almost imperceptible gesture.

Golbat plunged into the remaining darkness.

BGM: 'Powerful Predatory Deadly' 02:09–02:30

A fraction of a second later, a grotesque light burst forth from the darkness. Confuse Ray.

The beam was more piercing, more hellish than the previous ones. For a moment, Golbat's eyes no longer seemed to belong to a Pokémon. There was something vampiric about them, something ancient, something purely hostile.

Lance did not wait. Seizing the moment in that same distorted light, he recalled Golbat. The Poké Ball closed. Weezing appeared in its place, already crouched.

Electrode narrowly dodged the first Sludge, though with a slight delay in reacting. It unleashed Screech — not to strike immediately, but to probe.

Weezing responded with a precise, limited Haze, which neutralised the secondary effect without needlessly dispersing the field.

The battle settled back into a tense stalemate.

BGM: 'EP05 S02 04:40–06:02'

Eusine spoke first, in a low voice:

'What foresight... You didn't act out of panic. But out of strategic consideration. For fear that my Electrode's ability might be Soundproof... and nullify acoustic moves.'

Lance did not deny it.

"That compliment could have been directed at you. Your Pokémon have quite the advantage. And you took the trouble to examine my tactics with caution."

"Self-awareness," replied Eusine. "And you—you've even ruled out the possibility of lying in wait against me."

Lance fell silent for a second. Something flashed across his eyes, like a fleeting memory.

"My interventions aren't seen as cheating. I only resort to them when the situation becomes delicate... and the consequences risk being irreversible."

Eusine frowned slightly.

"How is that relevant...?"

"I am instructed to discipline our subjects. Including my counterparts. And to keep an eye on my boss. I only intervene when it becomes necessary. Otherwise... they wouldn't reach their full potential."

“You expect the very best from them... even though your equipment is so disproportionate?”

Lance nodded ever so slightly.

‘You don’t need to be strong to be dangerous. This is perfectly illustrated by Pokémon such as Golbat... or Murkrow. They aren’t particularly powerful. But they become lethal as soon as they seize the initiative at the right moment. In order to challenge my subjects and maximise their potential, I provide them with sufficient resources, but subject to certain restrictions. To confront their own limitations.’

Eusine stared at Weezing for a moment, then looked up.

“So... the atrocities in Ecruteak City... were just part of the training?”

“For your information: an experiment in Apollo’s methods.”

Lance uttered the name without the slightest hesitation, as if there were neither prohibition nor punishment to fear. Or as if it were a form of exploitation that had already been accepted.

“And I did not order any murders.”

Eusine’s eyes widened slightly.

“Are you denying it...?”

Lance understood the nuance. His reply came with an almost human reluctance, that of someone who had heard the question far too many times.

“I have simply not forbidden them. I allow it to happen... if it is to our advantage.”

Eusine felt a kind of inner heresy. Nevertheless, he said:

“Is that a way of diluting your responsibilities... and keeping your hands relatively clean?”

Lance did not look away. He did not blink.

“My hands are already stained, even without that. Addiction to sadistic complacency impedes cognitive and epistemic development. It really leads nowhere. And it comes at the expense of longevity... even for an organisation like ours.”

He spoke as though reading a routine, bureaucratic announcement, without waiting to be fully understood.

Eusine maintained a restrained but bewildered expression. The interpretations had just broadened his horizons in a pragmatic, detached... and profoundly unworldly way. Even as he still tried to rebel inwardly against this corruption.

Around them, the corridor of the tower remained silent. Only the snow, outside, continued to fall.

End of scene

Scene – The Urgent Tip: Green

Off the coast of Johto

BGM 'EP04 S01 03:47–05:00'

The sea was black and heavy beneath the snow.

The ship moved smoothly, too slowly for the urgency Green felt within him. He stood near the rail, dressed for winter, a travel bag at his feet — enough for an ordinary business trip.

In his hands he held a map of Johto, partially unfolded, and a positioning device more rudimentary than those he was accustomed to in Kanto. He was collating the directions, calculating the distance remaining to Goldenrod.

Close enough for his impatience to be mounting. Far enough that he risked arriving too late.

He had never truly explored Johto properly. The route remained passable, but the uncertainty gnawed at him more than his physical fatigue. His weariness was mainly mental. A kind of wear and tear accumulated over years of wandering that was too sedentary, too calculated.

He closed his eyes for a moment. The weighing up of his options swirled within him without reaching a clear conclusion.

Then he opened them again.

The decision was made.

He took out a Poké Ball and threw it with a precise motion. Pidgeot emerged into the cold air, its wings already half-open, alert.

BGM "EP04 S01 03:47–05:00" 00:54–

Green stepped forward, seized the reins with a nimbleness that stood in stark contrast to his earlier hesitation, and quickly checked the fastenings.

Behind him, a member of staff approached, still undecided.

"Excuse me... Are you cancelling the rest of your journey? The refund is..."

Green turned halfway round. The staff member then recognised him, and the sentence trailed off.

Green gave a faint smile. Austere, generous, without any air of aloofness. Just calm enough to bring the conversation to a close, just proud enough not to apologise.

"You can keep it. As a tip."

The crew understood. They did not press the matter any further.

Green climbed aboard. Pidgeot took a running start and soared into the snowy night, leaving behind the ship and the white wake that was already closing in.

The crew stood for a moment, watching the figure disappear into the opaque sky.

End of scene

Scene – Loooong live Master Giovanni

The Showdown: Apollo vs Gold/Richter and Athena vs Chris/Maria

The snow continued to beat against the tower's high windows.

Gold/Richter kept Fearow hovering, wings outstretched, without using Agility. Houndoom, lower down, lay in wait with an age-old, almost vampiric patience.

'However... this doesn't add up,' said Gold/Richter.

He had recalled a detail, without letting his voice falter.

"If your Pokémon only have biological moves..." said Gold/Richter. "Why was Lambda allowed to be the exception? A reward? To galvanise the grunts?"

Apollo tilted his head slightly.

"Does that raise questions...?"

"Yes. And if you'd allow me one more."

Further down in the tower, the same cry rang out again.

"Loooong live Master Giovanni...!"

Murkrow echoed Lambda's voice, more insistently, almost obscenely.

Chris/Maria did not look at Athena; she was staring at the bird.

"Why this insistence... on such a horrible voice?"

BGM "EP07 S01 05:36–08:06"

Gold/Richter continued, as if he had heard the echo:

"'Long live Master Giovanni'... A hollow saying. But why do your Murkrow imitate Lambda's voice specifically?"

Apollo replied without raising his voice:

"I shall answer both questions at once. Because..."

'...because we give our subordinates what they want.'

Athena's voice almost cut in on his.

Chris/Maria felt a wave of information wash over her as her face turned pale.

Gold/Richter stared at Apollo.

"The grunts... respond better to Lambda's voice?"

Apollo did not confirm this verbally. Just a simple nod, almost elegant.

"Why his...," said Gold/Richter. "And not Giovanni's?"

"Just as most trainers aren't as skilled as you."

A sense of foreboding washed over Gold/Richter.

Apollo continued, more slowly:

'They believe they are following charismatic figures. A master like Giovanni. Or brilliant people. In reality... they are more inclined to turn to what is on their own level. Towards what is vulgar. Accessible. Lambda, when he disguises himself as Giovanni... speaks to them better. He maximises their cohesion. So I granted him this exception. A significant reward for him. Modest, in my view, given what he brings to us.'

Gold/Richter said, almost in spite of himself:

"It seems as though he is the true king..."

"In a way. Yes."

Further down, Chris/Maria asked in a tense voice:

"You were using Giovanni... without any regard for him?"

Athena replied without animosity.

"I don't have the seniority to speak on the matter fully. I respect him. But not as a superhero."

Apollo continued, as if the conversation had not been interrupted:

"Lambda is a resource. A valuable one. He fills a role that we cannot fulfil ourselves."

"You tolerate all that vulgarity... just for that? Do we really have to go that far?"

"They do not actually worship Giovanni."

Gold/Richter spoke up, almost in spite of the weight of the words:

"They believe they worship him..."

"They glorify him. Yes. To justify what they need. Not what they truly admire. It's a self-delusion. Or a form of treachery... quite innate."

"Do they need... nothing more than an alibi?"

Apollo paused very briefly.

"They need a guardian. Or a predator strong enough... disguised as a king. They're not fools. Above all, they want to be able to vandalise, ruin, cross certain lines... without paying the price straight away. Ideology, grandiloquence, rhetoric... it's all just a smokescreen. They don't idolise. They protect a system that suits them. Submission isn't necessarily one-sided oppression, but undoubtedly: a lucrative and fair deal by design. They are co-investors, rather than victims."

Gold/Richter repeated, further down:

"So 'Long live Master Giovanni' ... it's just a signal. A licence."

“Exactly. A permission, not a cult. The leader has vanished. The system, however, keeps turning. Everyone knows it’s a mirage. But everyone benefits from it. All it takes is a few sinister birds... and a hollow phrase. Because Lambda’s voice fits perfectly with who they really are. And what they really want.”

Gold/Richter said nothing more. He accepted the observation in silence, with an almost existential austerity.

Apollo concluded, dispassionately:

“Your bewilderment is understandable. Under my regime, Team Rocket no longer possesses any romanticised grandeur. What remains is more primitive. More raw. I found it hard to admit, too.”

BGM: ‘My Sister’ 01:30–

Behind them, Houndoom barked once. Apollo turned his head towards the two Pokémon with the detachment of someone watching a mundane news item.

Houndoom had seized the opening. It lunged forward and launched a simple Pursuit at Fearow. The impact was heavy. The difference in level was palpable.

Fearow retaliated with Aerial Ace. The hit was clean, but the damage was uneven. Fearow was still holding out. Yet a sense of unease had clearly settled over Gold/Richter.

Further down, Chris/Maria sensed that the tide had just turned.

She remembered exchanging numbers with Eusine. She watched for another second, still not entirely convinced. Then she gave it a go.

She took out her mobile. Athena and Murkrow spotted it straight away. Despite this, she typed ‘37’ and sent the message.

At the same time, Venomoth assumed an attacking stance, wings spread, as if ready to unleash Psybeam.

Athena read her intention.

BGM: ‘My Sister’ 01:55–

A fraction of a second before the attack was fired, she recalled Arbok. The Poké Ball opened, absorbed the attack, and closed again.

Venomoth realised it was too late. The Psybeam had already left its wings. It struck empty air.

Murkrow waited until the Poké Ball had returned fully to Athena’s hand. As if even a manoeuvre of this sort still warranted a certain form of etiquette.

BGM: ‘My Sister’ 02:09–

Then it rose with a sharp, swift, almost vampiric movement. Its silhouette was sharper than usual.

Venomoth didn’t have time to release a single speck of powder.

Murkrow dived. Wing Attack.

A sharp rustle. The blow landed with the decisive force of a critical hit. Super Luck.

Venomoth collapsed, incapacitated.

Chris/Maria felt remorse wash over her all at once. The price was heavy. She didn't yet know if it had been worth it. She could only hope, in silence, that her Pokémon's pain had not been entirely in vain.

Outside, the snow was still falling.

End of scene

Scene – The Empirically Known Voice

Mt. Silver

BGM: 'Making Monsters' 00:00–00:44

Snow was falling thick and fast around Mt. Silver.

Red had been back down for a while. His pace remained steady, almost peaceful, despite the blizzard whipping the snowflakes against the walls of the building. A makeshift Pokémon centre, or some sort of public shelter for authorised travellers. The interior smelled of damp wood and emergency heating.

Outside, the wind howled.

Inside, several receivers were still working. A radio. A few old television screens. All the usual frequencies had gone.

BGM: 'Making Monsters' 00:15–00:44

Instead, a neutral, repetitive voice was broadcasting messages from Team Rocket. Instructions. Calls for calm. Vague promises of a 'new order' and the 'protection of common interests'. Nothing particularly strident. Just a methodical occupation of the soundscape.

Red paused for a moment by one of the devices. He briefly considered setting off. Going further down. Intervening.

Yet the weather rendered the notion absurd, and Johto remained largely unknown to him. The time was not right.

He narrowed his eyes slightly, weighing up his options.

Then the voice changed.

Another one. Male. Haughty. Imperturbable. Too measured to be insignificant.

BGM 'Red Eyes and Blue' 02:57–03:05

"...The old structures have sufficiently demonstrated their limitations. It is time to stop confusing nostalgia with responsibility. Those who know how to deal with reality have no need for grandiloquence."

Red opened his eyes again.

He didn't recognise that voice. He'd never heard it before.

Yet something immediately tightened in his chest. An intuitive premonition, without a clear image. As if he'd seen the man speaking before.

BGM 'Black Eyes' 01:35--end

The voice continued, as steady as ever:

'We do not demand your faith. Only your lucidity. The rest will follow.'

Red stood motionless.

The resonance deepened. Though he could not explain why, the voice reminded him of the man in white he had once glimpsed in the corridors of Silph Co. The one who kept reappearing in his nightmares. The one he sometimes caught a glimpse of, surrounded by black feathers, yet never quite able to make him out fully.

A brief but distinct trance came over him.

He no longer knew whether he should leave, stay, or simply keep listening.

A dull sense of helplessness settled over him, accompanied by an indescribable, almost nameless abashment, as if he had already failed at something without yet knowing what.

Outside, the blizzard showed no sign of abating.

End of scene

Scene – The Corrupt Order Apollo

Top of the Radio Tower

The snow was still pelting against the high windows.

Fearow remained hovering, without using Agility. Houndoom, further below, barely moved. It lay in wait with an ancient, calculated, almost vampiric patience.

Gold/Richter spoke again, his voice lower:

"So... intrinsic savagery, in your view... isn't limited to animals?"

Apollo replied with perfect detachment. Yet something flashed briefly across his face, as if he were stating a grim observation about the entire species.

"Human beings are also classified as animals. Or, at the very least, animality is part of them."

"Like the grunts...?"

Apollo nodded slightly.

BGM 'Reborn'

"Much of human behaviour is nothing more than ritualised emotions. Primitive. Brutal. Certain ways of speaking, exaggerated exclamations, proverbs, outbursts... On the whole, it is neither intellectual nor transcendent. It is absurd. And yet we repeat them. Because they're the result of an intrinsic

savagery. They believe they're acting freely. They think they're cultured. Whereas they remain driven by a very ancient bestiality. So much so that my conclusion is simple: most stories are accumulated errors. To be exploited. Not to be followed."

Gold/Richter almost frowned.

"But you're talking about innovation. Not regression. That shouldn't add up..."

"Savagery is not without its uses. It serves the purpose of survival. In the wild. In the face of physical challenges. It does not lead to true transcendence. For someone whose sole aim is survival, it is useful. For those seeking self-improvement, it is of almost no value. For the good, it is above all harmful. For evil... it is exploitable. Self-sufficiency blinds those who believe themselves to be good. It allows them to selectively ignore its harmfulness. As for me, I prefer to exploit it. To refine it. Rather than pose as a revolutionary."

Frustration was mounting within Gold/Richter. A kind of intellectual trance, barely contained.

"I see," said Gold/Richter. "You do not even deny being a manipulator. You manipulate anyone and everyone. Including the innocent. Like that red Gyarados. You forced it to evolve."

Apollo turned his head slightly, his gaze sharper, almost purposeful.

"...Are you certain of that?"

He tilted his head a little further, looking curious.

"If we'd forced its evolution by such crude means, it would probably have retained only erratic movements. The reflexes of a Magikarp under duress. Nothing more. Yet this Gyarados is dangerous. That suggests its evolution wasn't solely the result of brutal coercion."

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. He had just realised he had asked a question that was too obvious, too close to the consensus view. Intellectual embarrassment dampened some of his fury.

Apollo added, almost kindly:

"There are nuances in this area. Nuances which, I suppose, do not fall directly within your remit. Magikarp excels at little more than Tackle and... let us say, very basic moves. You know that better than we do, do you not?"

Gold/Richter clenched his jaw briefly. Then he launched an attack on another, more direct front:

"You gave Lambda a TM for Explosion. To instigate explosive raids. You're inciting him and his grunts to terrorism. To bloodshed. Whilst remaining incognito. Shielded from the consequences. Like the aristocracy. Is that correct?"

Apollo shook his head ever so slightly.

"I've never claimed that. If you're suggesting that I look down on them out of aristocratic snobbery... that's not the case."

"How so?"

The question came out more bluntly. Gold/Richter's perspective had just shifted.

"I yield honour only to those who know how to make the most of it with enthusiasm," said Apollo. "I call that courage."

Gold/Richter could no longer hold back his rage entirely.

‘Do you call committing atrocities “courage”?’

He had lingered too close to the scene of the crime. The words came out harsher than he had intended.

Apollo replied without raising his voice:

‘Sentimentality surrounding massacres is already a problem. Addiction to sadism is an even greater one. It overshadows and unleashes primal savagery, clouding judgement as much as it does creativity. It’s enshrined in the—let’s say— work code for our executives.’

“To the extent that Athena’s Murkrow pardoned me... It’s not that you reject murder, is it?”

BGM ‘Thunder and Blood’ from 01:16

“Every action has its consequences. Murder included. If the consequences happen to be naturally mitigated... we do not rule out taking advantage of that. So as not to squander certain resources.”

Gold/Richter spoke, almost exhausted:

“Your approach is truly... pragmatic. Heretical.”

Apollo did not reply straight away. His expression remained impassive, as if he fully understood the scathing assessment that had just been made of him.

Then he said:

“I get by with great difficulty. Because I am not exempt from the consequences of the seven deadly sins. Even if those who consider themselves good often commit them more frequently than I do.”

“Do you draw the same conclusion...? To Exploit the old faults?”

Apollo gazed for a moment at the snow outside the window.

‘Pride, lust, greed, wrath, envy, gluttony, sloth... are the most visible symptoms of savagery. Of animality. One does not achieve true sublimation by perpetuating them. One commits them mainly because one does not suffer their immediate consequences. One day, however. Many dogmas do not serve to elevate us. They serve, above all, to shelter despots. As if they were reserved for prey and the weak... whilst predators do without them. The truth is simpler. And crueller.’

Gold/Richter had lost some of his hostility. All that remained was a sense of bewilderment.

Apollo continued:

‘Countless predators have perished for having ignored this. For having indulged in excessive debauchery. In more popular—and more superstitious—language, this is called karma. In reality, it simply means that everything comes at a price. You collapse when you ignore it. Certain ancient teachings provide some guidance. But they remain incomplete. Not very rational. Not very scientific. They point out the problem. Rarely the solutions.’

After a moment’s pause, Apollo continued:

“Worship is a poor-quality commodity. It attracts those who need to believe in order to act. Men of this sort quickly go to the dogs. I don’t need to be idolised. I need people to act.”

"If remaining on the side of evil is so thorny... why such dedication?" asked Gold/Richter.

Apollo replied without any apparent cynicism. Almost with a kind of genuine detachment.

"Goodness is lovely. Precious. But costly. Evil is cheap. And more lucrative."

The words fell with heretical clarity.

"The shadow doesn't really despise the light. It's merely a question of economics. It isn't free. But it's cheap. And the shadow doesn't waste it either. Whereas those who believe themselves to be good, who extol peace and goodness, often treat them as inferior values. Almost free. And refuse to pay the true price to maintain them. Many people are, in fact, nothing more than primitive, gregarious predators."

Gold/Richter looked at Apollo's outfit:

"You dress in white... Isn't that pure hypocrisy?"

"For me, it's self-discipline. And innovation."

He glanced briefly at Houndoom, then out of the window, where a Murkrow was gliding across the snowy sky with an almost insolent ease.

"The Dark-type... a discovery from Johto. Whilst Murkrow and Houndoom were already lurking in Kanto. The land of crime. Not Johto. Evil adapts. It evolves. Just like my outfit. To survive, it ends up resorting to any means necessary."

A memory came back to Gold/Richter: the way Lance handled thresholds, interventions and discipline.

He hesitated, then said all the same:

'So... you cherish your grunts. Grunts. Even if they're vulgar. Even if they're cheap. Because they have a minimum value to you. And you don't waste them easily...'

Apollo didn't deny it:

"Sometimes I do cast them aside. Not out of snobbery. Nor out of contempt. I maintain a system. We depend on one another. A brotherhood... and a cold democratisation. I need a certain peace of mind to keep improving. To develop myself."

Gold/Richter was speechless for a moment.

"A sense of calm built on despair... An order born of chaos...?"

He had just touched upon something that took him completely by surprise. A distorted version of what he himself believed: that exceptions and champions also depend on the smallest, the most lucid amongst the ordinary.

Apollo replied simply:

"If the nature of the world is above all incorrigible... yet exploitable... then yes. It is the residual order. Even archaic. Even corrupt."

Outside, the snow had still not stopped falling. Houndoom had not moved. Neither had Fearow.

The silence that followed was heavier than all the previous words.

End of scene

Scene — The White, Snow-covered Hell

BGM 'Light in This Darkness' 00:00–01:52

Silence had settled in after the last words.

Apollo no longer seemed particularly interested in the outcome of the fight. He stood motionless for a moment, then a very faint smile touched his lips. There was no smugness about it. Rather, it was something strangely deferential, almost devotional.

As if he had just remembered that a true actor would have been able to convey this theme with greater grace. And that he himself was not quite qualified to recite it.

'By the way... Have you ever pictured what hell might look like?'

Gold/Richter replied rather quickly. Not out of naivety. Rather, so as not to be drawn into territory that was too conventional, too trivial.

"You criticise the supernatural. You consider it obsolete, don't you?"

"No. It needs to be made more structural. More scientific. So that it may finally become well-founded... and intelligible. Tell me your thoughts on the matter, young man."

Gold/Richter almost shrugged:

"Caves. Demons. Flames. Heat. Judges. In reality?"

Apollo tilted his head slightly.

"Correct. But I have the impression... that it stands right in front of us."

Gold/Richter frowned.

"What are you referring to...?"

BGM 'Light in This Darkness' 01:07–01:52

Without answering straight away, Apollo turned his gaze towards the vast floor-to-ceiling window. The movement was subtle. Yet Gold/Richter's eyes followed his, almost in spite of himself.

Outside, the snowy night stretched out, featureless. A few Murkrow flitted intermittently through the white. Otherwise... nothing. No distinct light. No stable shape. Only emptiness, whiteness, a vacuum.

A foreboding premonition immediately welled up in Gold/Richter's chest:

'You have chosen this day... to illustrate hell?'

Apollo did not look away from the landscape.

"Indeed. In hell, it snows. The snow conceals everything. You can no longer make out anything. No light. Nothing but snow. Because of the nonchalance that suffocates us. There are no flames. No

caves. No demons. No heat. All of that was merely imagined to veil what we have already contributed to. Pretexts. Hell is vivid. Tangible. And we're already there."

Gold/Richter managed to say, almost voicelessly:

"You're demented..."

BGM 'Light in This Darkness' 01:44–01:52

Apollo did not even turn his head towards him. The young man's bewilderment, the struggle, the immediate stakes... seemed no longer to affect him.

A dubious melancholy flitted across his features. It was impossible to tell whether he was truly succumbing to some form of distress, or whether this sadness served merely to help him regain his composure after having exposed himself too much, to forge his self-discipline once again.

He simply continued to gaze at the desolate landscape, with almost complete indifference.

The snow fell endlessly.

End of scene

Scene — two distinct approaches

Radio Tower, Secret Passage

BGM 'Light in This Darkness' 01:52–

They had already recalled their Pokémon.

The service corridor, further down in the tower, still smelled of warm dust and residual electricity. Outside, the snow continued to fall, indifferent.

Eusine stood motionless for a moment. The victory had been clear-cut, almost too clear-cut. Superiority in types, in preparation. Yet a deeper, more psychological weariness weighed on his shoulders. He was no professional at this sort of confrontation. His scruples always cost him more than the blows he received.

He looked down at his phone. A short message had just arrived.

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He could not quite hide his slight discomfiture, and Lance noticed it immediately.

Eusine looked up and met his gaze.

'Aren't you going to intervene...?'

Lance replied without resentment or remorse, as though he had merely completed a minor errand.

"I accepted the terms of the fight. I played, I lost. Verdict accepted."

"Isn't your job to eliminate intruders...?"

"If one chooses to achieve one's objectives through Pokémon, following the rules is the only way to make real progress. Breaking them is short-sighted. Counterproductive."

Eusine found himself saying, almost in spite of himself:

'...Is this a code of ethics for evil?'

"No doubt. The others wouldn't want me to perpetrate it. True progress does not stem from chaos or total disorder, but from making the most of existing order and rules."

Lance paused very briefly, then added, more precisely:

"On top of that, you chose me first. Because you'd taken the precaution of ensuring I wouldn't interfere in the other battles. You were more conscientious... precisely because you're less confident in your technique."

Eusine did not reply.

"So you weren't sure you could defeat Athena on your own. If I'd suspected as much... I've honoured my part of the bargain. They won't have any objections."

Eusine bowed his head slightly. His thanks came across as sarcasm—not vindictive, but almost weary.

"Thank you for your leniency... and for your commitment."

BGM "EP05 S02 18:12–18:59"

Lance regarded him for a moment longer.

"If you were faced with a challenge of this magnitude... would you consider my method? To intervene... at the opportune moment."

His tone was calm. Almost seductive. As if the mere act of resorting to it, whatever the motive, already corrupted something. As if victory, once achieved by this means, remained somewhat tainted. And exploitable.

Eusine pondered the proposal for barely a heartbeat, weighing it against both pragmatic and ethical criteria.

"...The situation might call for it, eventually."

He continued, more clearly, without giving everything away:

"Even if I were to resort to it... our motives would differ. Your method serves to avert the worst. To keep your allies in line. Not to cheat for the sake of it. Mine... would be not to break the rules simply because you are opponents. And to respect, as far as possible, the dignity of the young trainers."

He stopped there. He said no more.

Lance said nothing more.

They stood facing each other for a moment longer in the narrow corridor, whilst the snow continued to fall outside.

Their gazes remained locked in a discreet, appraising contest until the episode ended on that ambiguous note.

End of episode

Close of episode

Totals

≈ 13,400 words · 36 pp. A4 · read aloud ≈ 90 min.

Pass 1/3 — still open

Presents (takes care, rushes, continues). Weighing. Family in Heart. Radio Tower. Houndoom doublons. Durations excluding titles. Notes moved here. P1: screening → projection; self-immolation → immolation; leveller → niveleur; Long live → Looong live.

Version notes

2026-09-23 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Levels, Pursuit 80, Houndoom non-STAB historical, two Lances. Traces = address. Author filled. Title: Death Is Repetition.

Open for what follows

Man in white on the radio · Green · Houndoom still in play · 37.

BGM credits

Pieces: Castlevania: Nocturne (Netflix), Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Traces: duration only.